



YOU ARE **5 WEEKS AND 4 DAYS**

241 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

This image shows just how curled up the embryo is at this stage. The head end of the embryo is on the left. The embryo now has 22 pairs of somites (building blocks of the musculoskeletal system) running along the back.

“This is a crucial time for your developing baby as the neural tube, which will become the brain and spinal cord, is forming.”

This week your baby begins to grow rapidly and starts to become more recognizable as a fetus. There are three types of cells, each committed to a separate function. The first will form the skin and nervous system; the second forms blood vessels, muscles, and bones; the third forms the entire digestive system.

The cells responsible for the spine and nervous system are at work. Changing shape from a flat disk, the embryo starts to curl up. The edges of the groove that has already partially formed along the back gradually start to meet, closing and fusing to form a tube, which will become the brain and spinal cord. The last parts of the tube to close are at the very top of the head and then the base of the spine, two days later. Being careful to get an adequate intake of [folic acid](#) in early pregnancy is essential to ensure the neural tube closes completely, with no gaps.